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COL-314101

The morning began with soothing silence,

punctuated only by a soft, cool breeze.

And soon after, the first rays of sunlight broke through in full,

announcing the first gasp of spring.

A young Daoist rests atop a leafy tree, feathered by the spring breeze and shaded by the leaves, slowly drifting toward sleep.

Paper Heron: Hm?

Faint voices from below rouse her.

Paper Heron: ...

She leans in to listen carefully.

Paper Heron: Master? Finch?

Though drowsy from her rest, she leans closer still, trying to make out what the voices are saying.

Only to lose her balance and fall into endless darkness.

Inn, Chun Town

The sky above is a dull, pale gray. The first lunar month has just ended, and despite the melting of the ice and snow, the air feels colder than it should.

The innkeeper slowly paces about the courtyard with her hands behind her back before deciding to rest in an empty chair.

Innkeeper: It's freezing! Why hasn't that boy thrown more wood on the fire? Hm? Where is that lout, anyway?

bang

???: Didn't anyone teach you that there are rules out here?

???: I don't care about your rules. I follow my own principles!

Innkeeper: Is it too much to ask for a single day where no one draws their weapon in my inn?

The innkeeper sighs and slips away from her barely warmed chair, moving deftly around the corridor to hide herself.

???: *cough* Madam ...

Innkeeper: Ah! I was wondering where you'd gone off to. Avoiding your work, no doubt!

Waiter: This is hardly my fault! Besides, it's not as though we have any real customers today.

Innkeeper: Shh, be quiet! They might hear you!

Waiter: Alright, alright! I'll just take a quick look to see what's happening. Oh my, that man has a knife in his hand, but the girl he's facing actually looks calm, relaxed even.

Waiter: Wait, that peculiar mule of hers seems familiar.

clang

The innkeeper pulls the curious waiter back down and glares at him.

Innkeeper: What are you doing?! Are you trying to get the both of us killed?!

Innkeeper: *groan* Please don't break my elm tables and chairs. I only bought them this winter. Why must they start a fight just as we're closing for the night?

A sudden yawn comes from a forgotten corner.

???: Closing time already?

The young Daoist in red lifts her head from her arms. A crease from her sleeve has left a faint mark on her cheek.

She stands up and brushes off her clothes but looks reluctant to leave.

Daoist: But I haven't finished my mung bean cakes.

Innkeeper: Forget about the cakes. You'd better find somewhere to hide. There's going to be a fight!

Innkeeper: Should it get out of hand, some innocent bystander may get hurt. And that's the last thing I need on my conscience!

Daoist: A fight? Where? I don't see any—Oh!

Daoist: Hmm.

Waiter: What are you—Why are you sitting back down?

Daoist: Because there's nothing to worry about. That girl knows her limits. She'll be careful.

Waiter: What about the angry-looking man?

Daoist: The man? Oh, he's certain to lose.

Daoist: *yawn* So sleepy. This will take a while. Wake me when you close.

Innkeeper: What? This is no time for a nap!

The Daoist gives a casual wave of her hand, her head already resting on the table once more.

While the Daoist sleeps soundly, tensions run high near the gate.

Girl with a Mule: Even if they don't aspire to be a hero, a Daoist should never use their skills to cheat people!

Man with a Knife: Ha! Who spoke any words of heroes?

Man with a Knife: I won't let some irritating little bug lecture me! Come on, let's see what you're made of.

Girl with a Mule: It takes no strength to know right from wrong, and this is a wrong I cannot walk away from!

Man with a Knife: Big talk, little bug. Let's go!

Man with a Knife: Urgh!

The man, pushed back a step into the courtyard, nearly topples before steadying himself.

Girl with a Mule: Bug's waiting. Come on!

From his hiding spot, the waiter slaps a nearby wall in realization.

Waiter: I remember her! She was involved in that trouble at the pawnshop last month.

Waiter: Apparently, the pawnbroker Wáng was pressuring a customer to sell their family heirloom. That girl happened to pass by, so she intervened to try and reason with him. After exchanging only a few words, it escalated into a full-blown fight!

Innkeeper: Oh, that girl! She showed up just before the Dushuo Festival, if I'm not mistaken.

Innkeeper: I heard she was looking for the, the, what was it again, Qi flows?

Waiter: Whether she found it or not, she's certainly causing a world of trouble. Neither pawnbroker Wáng, talisman-seller Lǐ, nor the Head of the Armed Escort, Mr. Zhào, could stand against her.

The waiter counts out the names on his fingers, while the innkeeper shakes her head disapprovingly.

Innkeeper: She's certainly bitten off more than she can chew this time.

Innkeeper: ...

Innkeeper: Oh no, they're coming this way! Come, let's get out of here!

Innkeeper: Um, you there, are you coming?

Daoist: Hmm.

The sleeping Daoist only shifts place in response, clearly more interested in staying where she is.

As the fight draws closer, the innkeeper lets out a weary sigh, grabs her bumbling waiter by the collar, and rushes into the kitchen.

Man with a Knife: *sigh* So, you've got a few tricks up your sleeve after all. Not bad.

Girl with a Mule: If you return the money you swindled and swear to clean up your act, I'll let you go!

Man with a Knife: Ha! And what makes you think I'll stay true to my word?

Man with a Knife: That money is long gone. And I wouldn't be so confident if I were you.

With a glance at the napping Daoist, the man's sneer twists into a malicious grin. He flicks his wrist, sending his knife flying toward her.

Girl with a Mule: Watch out!

Gritting her teeth, she pivots and throws her longsword, sending it flying through the air and knocking the knife aside. She breathes a subtle sigh of relief.

clang

The longsword clatters to the ground, the sound almost lost in the man's bellowing laughter. With another sneer, he draws a second blade and brings it down in a heavy slash.

Daoist: Now that's a little much, don't you think?

The blade stops mid-descent, its edge caught between a pair of fingers.

White Qi coats the Daoist's fingertips. She turns and smiles at the stunned girl.

Daoist: Apologies for interrupting. I'm sure you can handle him yourself, but I just hate it when people don't play fair.

Daoist: I should've—No, my cake!

She swiftly brings her index and middle fingers together, tracing a sigil in the air. At once, the blade-knocked cake sails back onto the table.

Daoist: Phew! That was close.

Man with a Knife: A Daoist?

The man looks her over and notices the white jade sword at her side.

Man with a Knife: So you had a powerful master waiting for me, did you?

Daoist: Powerful master? Who? Where?

Man with a Knife: You're nothing but a fraud! Despicable little bug!

Girl with a Mule: I know nothing of her!

Daoist: Uh, I really only came for the cakes. Trouble showed up, so I stepped in. Nothing more, nothing less.

Daoist: Now that you've stopped, perhaps we can talk this out like reasonable people.

The man lashes out with another strike, harmlessly cutting through the air above the Daoist's head.

Daoist: *sigh* Not a talker, I see.

Daoist: With the flow of Qi, the mind opens wide!

[English text unavailable]

COL-314102

A red paper swallow flutters in the air, spins twice, then comes to rest on the tip of the man's knife.

Man with a Knife: Hmph. Is that all you've got?

The paper swallow teeters on the spot.

Daoist: Ahem! Sorry. Haven't done this for a while. Now!

Man with a Knife: Wh-What's happening?!

The man only stares, dumbfounded, as the swallow snatches the knife by the hilt and flies off with it toward the gate.

Man with a Knife: My knife!

Man with a Knife: You, you two ...

Man with a Knife: Hrgh! Fine. You and your master win this round, little bug. But don't let me see you in Chun Town again!

Daoist: What a coincidence. I was planning on moving on anyway.

Daoist: Oh, he's gone. I wonder if he heard me.

The Daoist sits back with a yawn and a lazy shake of her head, her eyes turning to the girl's mule.

Daoist: Your mule ... Perhaps you'd like to tie it up?

Girl with a Mule: Huh? Oh, right!

Gathering herself, the girl affectionately pats the mule's ear and ties it to a pillar.

Girl with a Mule: That was rather hairy. Thank you for dealing with that brute. My name is Pip, by the way. Would my rescuer be so kind as to give me hers?

Paper Heron: You're very welcome, Pip. They call me Paper Heron.

Pip: Lady Paper Heron!

Paper Heron: But just Heron will do.

Pip: Alright, Heron.

Pip: So sorry to have disturbed your rest. Please, allow me to repay you with a meal.

Paper Heron: Oh, there's no need for that. I still have my cakes to work through.

Pip: It would be remiss of me not to ... *gasp* Drop that right this instant!!

A sheet of snow slides down from the inn's eaves.

Paper Heron turns her gaze toward Pip's outburst.

The mule, somehow freed, eyes her slowly. Then, with a deft flick of its tongue, it swipes the last cake.

Mule: Whinny?

Paper Heron: Did your mule just ...

Pip: I swear to you, I didn't tell him to do that!

Paper Heron: Right, right. Not to worry.

Paper Heron: So, you said something about buying me a meal?

[English text unavailable]

COL-314103

White Horse School, ???

???: Heron?

???: Heron!

Paper Heron: Finch? I thought you were due to be back tomorrow?

Pearl Finch: So, what did you do with yourself while I was away?

Paper Heron: The only thing there is to do: recite texts, morning and evening, over and over.

Pearl Finch: And Master sighing in the courtyard has nothing to do with you?

Paper Heron: Well, he asked me a question, and I answered honestly.

Pearl Finch lets out a resigned, knowing sigh.

Pearl Finch: "Answered honestly." And what might that answer have been, exactly?

Paper Heron: Yesterday, before the morning class, Master went into his long lecture as always, and then asked each of us about our plans for the future.

Paper Heron: Brother Liǎng's aspirations are the same as always. He dreams of mastering the art of the blade, wants to carry the White Horse School's name far and wide.

Paper Heron: You can guess what Master said to that, "Our school's sword is not a tool for violence."

Paper Heron: Not a bad impression, eh?

Pearl Finch: Well, you would know how to do it. You are the one who puts that look on his face most often.

Paper Heron: Then Brother Sān stepped forward and said all who practice Daoism ought not to disrupt the natural flow of things but rather tend to their own minds—the very idea passed down from Ancestor Lǔ. You know the words: "When one's mind is tranquil and free of distracting thoughts, all things between heaven and earth will become one with it."

Paper Heron: Master got so angry he did that thing where he paced back and forth with his hands clasped behind his back.

Pearl Finch: Oh, what am I to do with you all?

Paper Heron: That's exactly what Master said!

Paper Heron clears her throat and puts her hands behind her back.

Paper Heron: "Ahem. Your honesty is commendable. However, you have chosen narrow paths, ones lacking true vision or growth. Pearl Finch, your senior sister, however, possesses a more expansive vision. You would do well to look to her as your role model."

Paper Heron: I was so happy for you, hearing such praise, that he caught me off guard when he suddenly asked me to share my own desires!

Pearl Finch: You told him you want to go down the mountain and sell mung bean cakes, didn't you?

Paper Heron: Yes, I ... Wait, how did you know that?

Pearl Finch: Brother Liǎng greeted me with the news before I even stepped through the gate.

Paper Heron's stern senior finally smiles.

Pearl Finch: If I recall, it was Taosu last time. Why the turn to mung bean cakes?

Paper Heron: Well, Taosu are much too tricky to make. I'd never get the crust crisp enough. Mung bean cakes are far easier.

Pearl Finch: Clearly you've thought this through.

Paper Heron: Of course I have. If spiritual development demands our full focus, then I say daily life does too.

Paper Heron: Master teaches that the Way is in everything. Brother Liǎng seeks it in the sword, Brother Sān in the mind. As for me, I'll look for it in my cakes. Perhaps we'll each find our way.

Pearl Finch: No wonder Master is upset. One fights, one studies, and one dreams of running a cake shop.

Pearl Finch: The White Horse School has soldiers, scholars, and even wanderers. Yet none will answer its true calling. None will take up the duty of subduing Lǎnzhū.

Paper Heron: That's not true. We still have you.

Pearl Finch: Me?

Paper Heron: We all know Master favors you. And you're the one who's been seeing to the school's affairs. It's only right that you inherit its legacy.

Pearl Finch: Me? I ... I don't think so.

Pearl Finch: Keeping Lǎnzhū subdued is our shared duty. A duty we all accept without hesitation. But, when the day is done, we each have different gifts.

She shakes her head and smiles, her shoulders dropping as she decides not to finish her thought.

Pearl Finch: Never mind.

Pearl Finch: So, I brought some fresh Taosu from town. I'm not certain they'll be to your liking, but ...

Paper Heron's hand darts out, retrieving a Taosu with masterful precision. She takes a bite, and her expression melts with satisfaction.

Paper Heron: Heavens above! This is the taste! Hm, why do mine never taste like this?

Paper Heron: Well, this confirms things. For me, the Way does not lie in Taosu. It is only in mung bean cakes that I shall discover my path.

Pearl Finch: Perhaps wait until you try some tomorrow before declaring your life's new mission.

Paper Heron: Tomorrow? What's so important about ... Wait! Do you plan to take me down the mountain?!

Pearl Finch: Not for fun. We've got some business to attend to down there.

Pearl Finch: And only if you promise me one thing. If Master asks you what you desire, please stop telling him you want to sell paper cuttings or snacks.

Paper Heron: Alright, fine. I shall tell only you.

Pearl Finch: He has high hopes for you.

Pearl Finch: It hurts him to hear you say it.

A ladle of hot oil splatters over the tofu, releasing the sharp aroma of spring onions and chili that hits the customers immediately.

Pip: Ah-Ah-choo! This tofu ... Is it supposed to have this white fuzz?

Waiter: Don't worry, miss. This is a Huanzhou specialty, hairy tofu. You won't find it anywhere else!

Pip: Oh, wow! It tastes incredible. Heron, you must try ... try some ... Ah-choo!

Paper Heron: Hmm, it's alright. Not too different from the tofu I've had before.

Pip: You don't like it? Let's get you something else.

Paper Heron: Ah, don't you fret. I'm just being picky.

Pip: No, no. I promised you a good meal, so a good meal you'll get. Excuse me, may I have—

Innkeeper: You want more? But you've already ordered eight dishes.

Pip: Oh, heh, would you look at that!

Pip glances at the full table and hesitates.

Pip: It seems none of these dishes were to your liking, Heron.

Pip: Will you still help me?

Paper Heron can't help but laugh.

Paper Heron: You've been generous to me, despite my picky habits. It would be wrong of me not to.

Paper Heron: You mentioned something about Lǎnzhū, correct?

Pip: We're both Daoists, so you must know the story, the one about the Huanzhou immortal who sealed the beast away.

Paper Heron: Yes, I know it. And you want my help dealing with this beast, eh? Hmm, that won't be an easy task.

Pip is startled by her directness.

Pip: Of course not! We don't have that kind of strength!

Pip: What I wanted to ask was, are you familiar with Qi stagnation?

Paper Heron: In a manner of speaking, yes. Though I'm not certain we're thinking of the same thing.

Pip: I've only heard my elders mention it. So, please correct me if I'm wrong.

Paper Heron: Go ahead. Tell me what they said.

Pip: The beast was subdued, but its influence on Huanzhou remains, causing some places to suffer from a stagnation in the flow of Qi.

Pip: I was told the danger varies. Sometimes it's little more than a tremor; sometimes it causes mountains to crumble or rivers to change their course.

Pip: But no matter the scale, it cannot be ignored. Left to fester, even minor stagnation can spiral into a catastrophe.

Paper Heron: Sounds about right to me. Though few possess this knowledge.

Pip: Mhmm. Those touched by the immortal's power are rare.

Paper Heron: The immortal? Oh, you mean the Daoist who once subdued Lǎnzhū.

Pip: Yes. About two hundred years ago, one of my ancestors passed near Zhu County and was fortunate enough to receive guidance from that very same immortal.

Pip: Of course, we don't come close to their level of skill. But we can still discern a thing or two through the flow of Qi.

Paper Heron: Two hundred years. Has it really been that long?

Pip: They say, for an immortal, a century is but a moment.

Pip: Anyway, while I was passing through, I noticed signs of stagnant Qi flow nearby, enough to tell me it could be serious.

Pip: Would you help me investigate them?

Pip: I swear, if you help me, I will come to your aid whenever you need it.

Pip: I don't know if I'll be of much use to someone like you, but I'll do whatever I can!

Paper Heron: Mmm. Alright.

Pip: What? You've agreed? Just like that?

Paper Heron drums her fingers on the table.

Paper Heron: Well, you know what they say, "Destiny brings people together."

Paper Heron: And it seems, in our own ways, we're both bound to that immortal.

Paper Heron: A rarer touch of destiny than most encounter in their lives, wouldn't you say?

[English text unavailable]

COL-314104

A cool evening spring breeze carries the scent of magnolia and the soft, damp breath of the river.

As night falls, the bustling market street winds down, and a vendor, carrying two baskets of unsold magnolia flowers, slowly walks toward its end.

Paper Heron leans on the windowsill, watching. She doesn't blink until the vendor disappears into the distant shadows.

Pearl Finch: What's on your mind?

Paper Heron: I was thinking every time I come down the mountain, there's so much that feels new.

Paper Heron: Like that play *Receiving Longevity*! That was my first time seeing a floating stage on the water.

Paper Heron: They were so far away. I could hardly see the person wielding the sword. But it must have been amazing. The cheers swelled like ocean waves.

Paper Heron: And the lanterns on the boats! They lit up the whole river!

Pearl Finch: Hm. We've come just in time for the Dushuo Festival. It's my first time seeing it all too.

Paper Heron: They weave such beautiful lanterns! The bamboo splints they use are shaved so thin and woven together as finely as thread. And when they move, it's like watching carp swimming in a lotus pond.

Pearl Finch: Brother Liǎng bought one once. Do you remember?

Paper Heron: You're right, he did! But I like these lanterns more.

Paper Heron: Though I'm not so sure about all the new food. Tofu with white fuzz, fish with strange flavors. Not to say they're bad, but ...

Paper Heron: And the magnolia seller just now, we also saw one at the city gate this morning.

Pearl Finch: Magnolia flowers ... Yes. You can take some back, if you like.

Paper Heron: Hmm, I would like some. But I'm worried they'll wilt before we make it back up the mountain.

Paper Heron: It's better that someone else buys them. They'll last longer that way.

Waiter: Here you are, your tea.

As they're talking, a waiter arrives with their tea and two plates of delicate pastries.

Tavern, ???

Waiter: These pastries are a delicacy from the Wu region. I hope you enjoy them.

Paper Heron: You have pastries from Wu?

Waiter: Yes, indeed. We are the only establishment in all of Huanzhou that sells them.

Waiter: See that ferry out there? Delectable as they are, these pastries don't keep for long. They're best fresh from the boat. Were they to be sent to the next town, they'd lose their flavor before they ever arrived.

Waiter: Huanzhou is all mountains, which makes travel difficult. But there is a ferry just east of our Chun Town. Thanks to that, we can use horses and boats to deliver these pastries here while they're still fresh.

Waiter: Wu-style pastries are the finest, though they tend to be very sweet. I do hope they're to your liking.

Paper Heron: Thank you. Now I have to try them!

She picks up the nearest one and examines it carefully.

Paper Heron: Master says I'm from Wu too, so what's so spec—

Paper Heron: What in ... Bleh, it's sweet! It's filled with red bean paste!

Waiter: I did warn you. And before you ask, no. There are no refunds.

Pearl Finch shakes her head with a smile and pushes a cup of clear tea toward Paper Heron.

Pearl Finch: Drink this. It will cut the sweetness.

With this spring's tea leaves not yet ready, the establishment still serves last year's tea. Its leaves are aged, but the brew is light and clear.

Paper Heron: This mung bean cake tastes nothing like the ones our brothers bought! By my eye, it seems they've used sticky rice and sesame oil. I wonder how they mix it all together.

Paper Heron: If I were to sell them, I wouldn't use that rock-sugar bean paste. I'd go with something lighter.

Paper Heron: Hmm. But what's better? Maybe salt and pepper?

...

...

Paper Heron: Finch? Are you still listening?

The wind picks up, bells chime gently under the buildings' eaves, and a pair of resting birds fly away, startled.

Pearl Finch: Heron, is it truly your desire to go down the mountain and sell cakes?

Paper Heron: Of course. But I can't just leave.

Paper Heron: Just like our brothers. They don't really want to stay on the mountain either, do they?

Paper Heron: Brother Liǎng ... I've watched him practice with his sword. He's amazing! He wields his blade like the heroes in a story—the ones whose swords can cut water.

Pearl Finch: But our techniques focus on regulating Qi, concentration, and visualization. The Longevity Sword cares little for physical sharpness.

Paper Heron: True.

Paper Heron: And Brother Sān lives only for poetry and song. When I first came, he'd have his nose in a book of verses all day. All that knowledge, and he still couldn't remember the grandmaster's full title.

Paper Heron: Convincing him to read Daoist texts for decades would be a real challenge.

Paper Heron: You've all been so kind to me—stayed with me. How could I possibly leave you behind?

Pearl Finch: Ah, you ... I can't even ...

Pearl Finch: Do you have any idea how many dream of joining the White Horse School to learn the Method of Longevity? And yet, the three of you act as though it's nothing.

Paper Heron: But what's the difference between selling cakes and studying the Method?

Pearl Finch: There you go again.

She lets out a long, weary sigh.

Pearl Finch: Of course there's a difference.

Street, Chun Town

Half-melted snow leaves the ground slick with mud.

At times like this, few are willing to brave the streets, save for a couple of tired-looking market stall vendors leaning against the roadside.

Young Vendor: You know, I reckon we should head to the big fair in Zhu County next year. What's the point of staying in Chun Town?

Tired Vendor: *sigh* I'll think about it.

Young Vendor: What is there to think about? Look around, the town's empty! The only way to make money here is by depending on travelers or getting into some shady business. And the second is not an option for us.

Tired Vendor: I know, I know. But my family has lived in Chun Town for generations. Leaving isn't as easy as all that.

Young Vendor: Not like it's any different for me. But you know what they say, "A transplanted tree dies, but a relocated person thrives." You ...

Suddenly, the sound of hooves cuts through their conversation.

Paper Heron: Excuse me, can you tell me how to get to the East Port?

Young Vendor: East Port?

Tired Vendor: I can tell from your accent that you're not a local. If you're going to the Zhu County fair, then the port is the wrong direction.

Paper Heron: That's quite alright. I'm not heading to Zhu County.

Tired Vendor: Forgive my asking, but why are you going there alone?

Tired Vendor: That place is all but deserted.

Paper Heron: Oh, I'm not traveling alone. I have a friend with me. She forgot the way, see, so I thought I'd come back to ask for directions.

Young Vendor: Excuse my friend here, miss. What you do or where you travel is none of our business.

Young Vendor: See the Paifang ahead? Go past it, head straight east, cross the woods to the river, then follow it downstream.

Paper Heron: Thank you kindly.

She bows and turns to leave but stops short, remembering something.

Paper Heron: One more thing: Does the East Port have a ferry?

Tired Vendor: It did, once upon a time. But it's been empty for a long while.

Paper Heron: I thought as much. I believe I've traveled on one there before.

Tired Vendor: You must be joking.

Tired Vendor: Even in my grandfather's time, the ferries were deserted.

Tired Vendor: When could you have possibly traveled on one?

[English text unavailable]

COL-314105

Forest, Chun Town

The melting snow now lies thick, soaking last year's fallen leaves and branches.

Pip slogs ahead through the mud, pulling her mule behind her.

Pip: *pant* I thought the path would be easier once it warmed up.

Paper Heron: We can take a breath here if you like?

Paper Heron takes the mule by the reins and ties it to a dead tree beside the path.

Paper Heron: Is there a reason you don't ride your mule?

Hearing the question, the mule looks up at the Daoist, then drops its head and continues its search for seeds under the leaves.

Pip: Because he isn't mine.

Pip: The Qi stagnation we're seeking stems from somewhere near an old man's house near the East Port.

Pip: I wasn't able to fully explain what Qi stagnation is to him. Still, he understood I wanted to help and insisted on giving me this mule.

Pip: But until I've finished what I came here to do, I can't accept his reward.

Pip affectionately pats the mule's back.

Mule: Whinny?

Paper Heron gives a nod of approval and gives the mule several pats of her own.

Paper Heron: You're right. It's the proper way to do things.

Mule: Whinny!!

Pip: Heron, you said you've been to the East Port before. When was that?

Paper Heron: I don't recall exactly, but I know it was very many years ago.

Pip: But you don't appear to be much older than I am.

Paper Heron: And how do you know I haven't used a technique to preserve my youth, hm? Or that I draw power from moonlight? Apply storax ash to my face each night? Or drink a specially brewed tonic made with the purest water?

Pip: Really? Which one is it? What's your secret?

Paper Heron: Haha! None. You're so gullible. I can't help but wonder how your family allows you to travel alone.

Pip: *cough*

Pip: I think I've rested enough. Time to move. Maybe we can reach town before dark.

Pip looks around, her gaze darting between unfamiliar landmarks.

Pip: I think I'm lost again.

Pip: Through the woods to the east, right? Umm. Which way is east?

Pip: Heron, is east to our left or right?

An hour passes.

Pip: Ah, we're back where we started. Heron, you don't know the way either!

Paper Heron: Well, I always followed my seniors. I never had the need to learn how to find the way myself.

Paper Heron: But since we're looking for the Qi stagnation, perhaps I can come up with a different solution to help guide us.

Paper Heron: Channel the power of the Way!

Paper Heron opens her palm and blows, her breath gently lifting a paper swallow to the breeze.

It wobbles in the air for a moment before tilting its head back.

Paper Heron: I left a trace of Qi on it. As long as we're not too far, it should be able to guide us to the stagnant Qi.

Paper Heron: My only hope is that we haven't wandered too far.

Pip: But ...

The swallow circles Paper Heron twice, then lands on her hair and begins pecking at its wing.

Paper Heron: Huh. It's never flown that fast before. Pip, did you see which way it went?

Pip: Uhm. It seems to be on your head.

Paper Heron: On my head?

She pauses, then retrieves the paper swallow from her hair. Cupping it in her palm, she brings it up to her eye level.

The swallow remains still, all previous signs of life absent.

After a moment, Paper Heron sighs.

Paper Heron: Alright. I understand. It's no fault of yours. But we need you to find something else.

Whispering to the swallow in words Pip cannot understand, she swiftly sketches signs in the air with her index finger before clapping softly.

Paper Heron: Go!

The swallow scans its surroundings, then flaps its wings and drifts toward the brush on the right.

Paper Heron: There! Not a bad trick, eh?

Forest Depths, Chun Town

Pip: *pant* This technique of yours ... Is it similar to what you did to that brute's knife back at the inn?

Paper Heron: Good eye. It's just a little trick I picked up. I can teach you if you like.

Paper Heron: Come to think of it, we were so busy finding the way there that I failed to ask: why were you fighting that man in the first place?

Pip: He's a fraud, one that almost fooled me too!

Pip: He had set up a fortune-teller's stall by the bridge. He claimed the land was cursed, blaming it for the town's decline, and offered to cleanse the misfortunes in exchange for offerings.

Pip: At first, I thought for certain he'd know more about Qi stagnation, so I wanted to ask for his advice. But after observing him for two days, I realized he was a fraud.

Pip: He had enough skills to convince the villagers, sending dead leaves spinning in the air, making pebbles float. That sort of thing.

Pip: But when I confronted him, we'd hardly spoken a few words before he'd drawn his blade.

Paper Heron: I see. But before you fought, did it ever occur to you that you might lose?

Pip: I wasn't about to stand back and let him swindle those poor people out of their money. Besides, you can only be sure of victory if you fight.

Paper Heron: And what was your plan if you didn't win?

Pip: I figured someone like you would step in and put things to rights.

Paper Heron: What if there wasn't anyone?

Paper Heron moves a dead branch out of Pip's path.

Pip: Thank you. If I'd failed, I'd have retreated.

Pip: There'd be no shame in losing. And when I'm older and stronger, I would return and win.

Pip: When I'm ... Well, when I'm around your age, I doubt I'll lose to anyone.

Paper Heron: My age? That's a lot further away than you might think.

Paper Heron: I have to say, your strategy of retreating when you can't win is truly a Daoist act. Follow the heart and accept the natural way of things.

Pip walks a few steps ahead in silence, eventually speaking with her back still to Paper Heron.

Pip: That fraud spoke lies, but his words about the town failing? Those seem true.

Pip: The old man who gave me this mule said Chun Town was once a bustling place. Now it's only lively during the big fair in Zhu County nearby.

Pip: Can stagnant Qi flow make a place, make so many lives, go wrong?

Paper Heron: Maybe. "Plants die. Water turns foul. Animals leave." It all can happen. But we need to see for ourselves.

Paper Heron: Many things can change a town's fortune.

Pip: Ever since I came down the mountain, I've tried to right wrongs—fight when I see injustice. I've even exposed a few cheats along the way.

Pip: Pawnbroker Wáng forced low prices and exploited the townspeople. I argued with him.

Pip: Tianshi Lǐ deceived his patients by selling incense ash as elixirs. I called him out.

Pip: And Zhào, Head of the Armed Escort, let his men bully the merchants. So, I fought him too.

Pip: But ... But nothing seems to have changed.

Pip: Maybe I just don't know enough yet. If I were like you, or even better than you ...

Paper Heron: That wouldn't change anything.

Paper Heron: You have a good heart, Pip, and your mind is in the right place. But there are some things no one person can do.

Paper Heron: Great skills can make a dead tree sprout and a flower bloom for a hundred years.

Paper Heron: But no one can return to a spring that has already passed. All things flow as they will.

Paper Heron: ...

Paper Heron suddenly tilts her head, listening to something in the near distance. Then she smiles.

Paper Heron: Forget it. Let's just focus on what's in front of us.

Paper Heron: Listen. Do you hear water?

[English text unavailable]

COL-314106

Apricot Tree, East Port

Pip: Your paper swallow is amazing!

Paper Heron: Is this really the East Port? It looks nothing like I remember.

Paper Heron: Hmm, it's quite different from the town too.

Frost still clings to the trees near the water, barring signs of life or greenery. Ahead, the river moves slowly, cutting its path through stretches of dry grass and sandbars.

Near the door of a tall, worn house, an old man with white hair and a beard stares at one of the dead trees.

Pip: I was just thinking the same thing. What do you ...

Suddenly, the mule lifts its head and brays. Then, without warning, it charges forward.

Mule: Whinny!

Pip: Hey, you! Don't be so impatient!

???: You're back? Didn't I tell you to accompany this nice young lady?

The mule stops beside the old man.

Pip: It seems more comfortable here with you.

Pip: I only want to do the right thing, sir. There's no need to give me anything in return.

Elder: No, no. What would an old man like me do with a mule anyhow?

Elder: You're a strong, good fellow, aren't you, boy? You'd be wasted with me, don't you think?

Mule: Whinny!

Elder: I know, I know. I'll miss you too. But this is for the best.

Elder: Once, many people passed through here. I made enough to feed you back then. But now, well, I'm sorry. I can't anymore.

He gently strokes the mule's ear and sighs.

Elder: Look at me, going on about a mule. What brings you back so soon?

Pip: You can rest assured, sir. Help has arrived. This is Paper Heron.

Pip: I may have lacked the skills to finish what I'd started, but I'm certain that she will be able to help!

Paper Heron smiles at the old man and glances thoughtfully at the dead apricot tree nearby.

Paper Heron: Hmm. Seems we've come to the right place.

Elder: Oh, don't trouble yourselves. The good days are long gone, and they're not coming back.

Elder: *sigh* Madam, I apologize for getting you involved in this nonsense.

Pip: It is not nonsense!

Elder: *sigh* There's a strong wind in the air. If you're to stay, please, come inside to talk.

Old House, East Port

Elder: It's not much, but you're welcome here. Allow me to make you some tea.

Bright light streams through the window, making the time-worn carvings difficult to see.

Inside, the furniture is fine but old, lending the room a solemn air.

Pip: Alright, while he's making tea, let's speak frankly.

Paper Heron: Frankly? About what exactly?

Pip: Heron ...

Pip: The old man doesn't understand what's going on. How can he? But we both know this place is suffering from Qi stagnation.

Pip: On the way here, did you notice anything unusual?

Paper Heron: Now that you mention it, yes. There were a few oddities on the road.

Pip: Such as?

Paper Heron: Let's see: I got woken up by a fight, had my cakes stolen by a mule, and spent most of the trip wandering around lost. Quite the peculiar turn of events, wouldn't you say?

Pip: Not that kind of "unusual." I'm talking about the Qi flow!

Paper Heron: Hmm. It is true that this was once a busy ferry crossing.

Elder: Oh my, few remember that old ferry now.

The old man hobbles over with a platter of coarse porcelain bowls filled to the brim with strong tea.

He sets them on the table, its lacquer worn and patchy but its surface clean.

Elder: This is a local blend. When the ferry thrived, even the people of Wu loved it!

Elder: It can't quite compare to the fancy teas folk prefer now. But it'll certainly quench your thirst.

Paper Heron: This will do nicely, really. I'm not picky.

Smiling, she takes a generous sip.

Paper Heron: Oh my, this tea is good! Better than most I've tried. Pip, you really must take a sip.

Pip: Me? I ... I tried it last time.

Pip holds her warm bowl in her hands, but her focus remains anywhere else.

She hesitates, then leans forward, looking at her companion across from her.

Pip: I know you know more than you're letting on. Please just tell me the truth.

Pip: Do you think Chun Town went downhill because there's something wrong with the Qi here?

Outside the window, a dead leaf falls in silence.

Paper Heron: No.

Pip: No?

Paper Heron: The Qi here is blocked, that much is certain. But you can't pin a whole town's bad luck on just that.

Paper Heron: As I said before, there could be many reasons for what's happening here. It could be the shifting of trade roads or simply a turning of the human heart.

Paper Heron: In the end, everything has its season.

Paper Heron: Not everything comes from magic and sorcery, nor can they be fixed by them.

Elder: She's right.

Elder: I don't understand Qi like the two of you seem to.

Elder: But the new trade routes that opened all go through Zhu County, so the ferry and town fell silent. That's just how things are.

Elder: Please excuse her, madam. She's young, and her heart is in the right place. She believes everything must have a reason, a solution.

Pip: So it's not the Qi?

Paper Heron: I never said it wasn't. Stagnant Qi flows do pose a bit of a problem.

Paper Heron pauses for a moment in thought before changing the topic of conversation to a more optimistic motif.

Paper Heron: "Spring comes upon a withered tree." True, I cannot bring spring back. But making an old tree bloom again? That I can do.

Elder: What?!

Elder: It used to be a local custom to plant trees here, back when the ferry still ran.

Elder: For those returning, the sight of our tree standing guard was how we knew we were home, even before the ferry docked.

Elder: My family has lived by the ferry for generations. This apricot tree was planted by my ancestors. It's a reminder of home. Many generations have lived under its shade.

Elder: My grandfather stood under this tree when he sent my father off to work on the water. My father stood under it to see me push off for the first time. And every time we returned home, the tree was the first thing we saw.

Elder: And now the ferry is dead. Sometimes I think that the ferry, this tree, and I are all too old.

Elder: If it could bloom again, that would grant this old man his dearest wish.

Paper Heron tilts her head in thought, a wry smile forming on her lips.

With a small flourish, she conjures a red paper-cut Mei blossom. It drifts down to settle on the worn table.

[English text unavailable]

COL-314107

Apricot Tree, ???

Boatman: Three, two, one. Good. Throw the line! Slowly now. Don't hit anything!

Deckhand: Where's the tea? I need a hand!

The last of the cargo is loaded, and the bustle at the ferry terminal fades into a murmur. Sunset dances an apricot tree's shadow on the water, while a white bird glides over its golden surface.

Paper Heron: This is the place with Qi stagnation? It seems normal to me.

Paper Heron: I was expecting crumbled mountains and barren earth.

Pearl Finch: No wonder Master's mad at you. You hear only what you want to hear.

Pearl Finch: What you're describing is the chaos of Qi when Lǎnzhū awakens. Qi stagnation is entirely different.

Paper Heron: Ah, yes, that's right. I remember now!

Paper Heron: A place suffering Qi stagnation is effectively sealed shut. Nothing in it changes, grows, or dies. Right?

Pearl Finch: Close, but not quite. To seal away Qi altogether would require a very powerful artifact.

Paper Heron: Like Master's sword?

Pearl Finch: Oh, Heron, always drawn to the most peculiar things.

Pearl Finch: More often, the life force in such places quietly fades away. You might not notice it at first, but over time, this decay becomes evident.

Paper Heron: That sounds serious.

Pearl Finch: It could be major or minor. A mountain might collapse, or a small patch of grass might wither. No one can predict what will happen until the signs appear.

Paper Heron: So the whole town could suffer a serious disaster. Or just ...

She glances up at the apricot tree she leans against.

Paper Heron: This apricot tree here might not bloom again?

Pearl Finch: Yes. Either way, we should act before any trouble arises. Better to be safe than sorry.

Pearl Finch: From what I can gather, there are traces of Lǎnzhū's last awakening still lingering here. The flow of Qi is still partially blocked.

Pearl Finch: It's nothing too serious, but it's hard to rid it for good. It will need cleansing now and then.

Paper Heron: Really? That's great!

Paper Heron: Ahem. I mean, good. Yes. I can help you whenever you come down the mountain.

Paper Heron: Any thoughts on when you'll be coming down next?

The older Daoist looks at her, amused.

Pearl Finch: I'd say about two hundred years from now. Give or take a decade.

Pearl Finch: By then, you'll be able to travel on your own. You won't need to follow me.

Paper Heron: Two-Two hundred years?!

Pearl Finch: Two hundred years ago, this was wild land, you know. No one lived here. Now it's a port with ferries and traders busying its waters.

Pearl Finch: Who knows what it will be like in another two hundred years. The waters and fields will remain, but the sights will surely change.

A river breeze blows along the water's edge, knocking a few white and pink petals from their branches.

Paper Heron catches one, holding it up to examine its dry, yellowed edge. Letting it fall to the ground, she turns her gaze to the treetop.

Paper Heron: In two hundred years, this tree could grow to be as tall as the Mei tree at our school.

Pearl Finch: Perhaps, if it's lucky, if no axe cuts it down, if no disaster strikes.

Pearl Finch: Or, in two hundred years, it could be forgotten.

Paper Heron: Hmm. I thought you'd be disappointed once you learned we're just saving one tree.

Pip: I made a promise to the old man to help, and I will.

Pip: Besides, saving a tree is a good thing.

Pip: But where do we start?

The girl stares up at the long-barren tree, unsure of how to proceed.

Pip: I did some investigating of my own. Clearing the Qi won't be the only difficulty. There's also an enchantment placed here by an immortal.

Pip: I think this immortal saw the problem and placed the enchantment to clear the Qi. Clever, but over a hundred years have passed. The enchantment has decayed, letting the Qi stagnate once more.

Pip: How am I supposed to fix an immortal's work?

Paper Heron: Not to worry. I know how.

Pip: You do?!

Paper Heron: Intricate as this enchantment may be, it is no immortal's skill. Just a common ritual from my school. I've seen it many times since I was a youth.

Pip: Your school ... You didn't mention much about it on the way here. What's it like?

Paper Heron: It's in Huanzhou. But we keep to ourselves up in the mountains, so you may not have heard of it.

Pip: Hmm. It sounds like a nice place to learn and grow your skills, away from the world.

Paper Heron: Not exactly. My master once said that, in the old days, our seniors often descended the mountain. There's even a tale of a sage asking the head of our school for guidance. But that was long ago. No sect lasts forever.

Paper Heron: As for the students ...

Pip: They must all be skilled cultivators of Qi. Like you.

Paper Heron: Like me? Yes, and no. Each of us walked a different path.

Paper Heron: I was the last to join, see, and I'd always been a bit of a handful. Still, they all cared for me.

Paper Heron: Brother Liǎng was impatient and quick-tempered, always training the sword. He didn't quite fit the image of a master, more like a storybook villain. He ventured down the mountain more than anyone—loved meddling in other people's affairs.

Paper Heron: Brother Sān hardly spoke, choosing only to read the Daoist texts over and over. He had the appearance of a master, but he loved to lecture and scold people. And when he did speak, his words were often so fancy that sometimes I think even he didn't know what he was talking about.

Paper Heron: ...

Paper Heron: I also had a senior sister at the school. We were the closest.

Paper Heron: She was kind. Master liked her. Whenever there was trouble, we went directly to her. And if Master was going to punish someone, we'd ask her to intervene.

Paper Heron: But she didn't quite fit the image of a master either.

Paper Heron: The masters in tales are always ill-tempered, but not her.

Paper Heron: She ...

Another river breeze ripples the face of the water, and several dead leaves float down from a bare branch.

Pip: Heron?

Paper Heron seems totally lost in the branches of the apricot tree.

Paper Heron: Hmm? Oh. Sorry. I was lost in thought.

Paper Heron: Now, this enchantment. It's not one I've ever studied formally, but it's common enough knowledge in the school. It shouldn't prove too difficult.

Paper Heron: Here we go.

Paper Heron puts two fingers together, takes in a shallow breath, and releases, white Qi swirling at her fingertips.

Pip: Wow!

Paper Heron: With the flow of Qi, the mind opens wide!

She draws a complex sign in the air—one Pip has neither seen before nor understands—then points toward the tree.

Paper Heron: Now!

A clear wind carrying withered grass sweeps over the treetops.

Paper Heron: ...

Pip: Is that it?

Pip: I know you said it wasn't difficult to fix, but I was hoping there'd be more of a show.

Paper Heron: Ahem. Well, as you said, fixing it wasn't hard.

Paper Heron lets out a slightly awkward cough.

Paper Heron: But, despite my efforts, a problem still remains. Things are a little different from what I'd thought. I'll have to think of another solution.

Pip: A little different?

Paper Heron: Just a little! The enchantment is indeed from my school, yes. But the way to fix it ... Hmm. I'll have to think on that.

Paper Heron: This enchantment is simple but elegant. To fix it, I'll need to guide the Qi using the same method employed when it was first cast.

Paper Heron: But the enchantment is feeble. If I use too much power, I'll destroy it. One wrong move and it's gone.

Paper Heron: I need to be very careful. Wait a moment.

Paper Heron pauses mid-cast. She moves closer to the tree and taps its trunk hesitantly.

Paper Heron: This enchantment feels familiar. It feels like my senior sister's work.

Pip: That's great! Then it should be easier to solve, right?

Paper Heron: I'm not sure.

Pip looks at Paper Heron, confused, but she doesn't look back. Instead, her gaze is fixed on the seemingly benign tree trunk, lost deep in thought.

Pip: You said you often came down the mountain with your seniors. Perhaps you came here with your senior sister before?

Paper Heron: Perhaps that's so.

Pip: From what you've said, it sounds like you were close.

Paper Heron: Yes, we were.

Pip: Well, since you know the caster so well, you must be familiar with her habits and style.

Paper Heron: ...

Paper Heron: I have little memory of what happened back then.

Pip: Oh, I see.

Pip taps her chin with her forefinger, thinking as she circles twice around the tree.

Pip: Oh! I have another idea.

Pip: The ritual is your senior sister's, so the key is to mimic her style. Wouldn't the easiest way be to ask her?

Pip: At first, I was stuck, so I came to you. But now you're unsure too. The only route left to follow is to find the original caster.

She speaks earnestly, growing more confident with each spoken word.

Pip: Yes! We'll likely be gone for a while, meaning we'll miss this spring's blossoming season. But as long as we resolve the Qi stagnation, we can come back next year.

Paper Heron: Finding her might be difficult.

Pip: Why? Is she traveling? In seclusion? It doesn't matter. You're from the same school. You must have a way to reach her.

Paper Heron: A way to reach her ...

Paper Heron: It is possible, but I never learned how to summon a spirit.

Pip: Wait, what? Summon a spirit?

Pip: You mean she's no longer with us?

[English text unavailable]

COL-314108

Paper Heron: Is that it?

Paper Heron's senior sister sheaths her sword with practiced ease.

Pearl Finch: Heron, stop staring. It's not a difficult spell.

Paper Heron: But the way you wove the enchantment was impressive! Can you teach me?

Pearl Finch: You haven't been with us long enough to understand our school's core teachings. Even if you learned the forms, they'd be little more than empty poses, and you'd be unable to cleanse the Qi.

Pearl Finch: With your natural talent, in ten years or so, you'll have built a solid enough foundation that weaving this enchantment will come easily.

Paper Heron: But what if I need to use it before then?

Pearl Finch: If such a need arises, come find me, another senior student, or even Master himself.

Paper Heron: And if I'm out alone and can't reach anyone?

Pearl Finch shakes her head and chuckles.

Pearl Finch: You're just asking questions until I say "give it a try," aren't you? With so many new things to explore, one would think you'd be content enough as it is.

Pearl Finch: Have patience, sister. Ten years is a short time. Follow Master's teachings, and I promise you, your time will come.

Paper Heron: Ten years is a short time? That's over three thousand morning and evening classes. Over three thousand recitals of the *Scripture of the Big Dipper*.

Pearl Finch: *chuckles* Ah, Heron, so young, so impatient.

Pearl Finch: Ten years may feel long now, but someday you'll look back and see it all as just a moment.

Paper Heron: Later, sure. But "later" isn't here yet! Right now, it's forever away.

Pearl Finch: ...

Pearl Finch: *sigh* Heron ...

Pearl Finch: Master hasn't told you yet, but he intends to pass the two Longevity Swords to you.

Pearl Finch: Longevity ...

Pearl Finch: Do you know what longevity means? Truly means?

Pearl Finch: Our school's practices already extend our lives to be longer than most. And you, with your natural talent and a mind so ready to grasp our core teachings, are a rarity.

Pearl Finch: You must trust me when I say your "forever" will be longer than any of ours.

Paper Heron: Only mine?

Paper Heron: But what about the rest of you?

Pip: Heron, are-are you alright?

Pip: It's my fault. I shouldn't have suggested ...

Under the apricot tree, Paper Heron opens her eyes, the here and now slowly coming back into puzzling focus.

Paper Heron: Hmm? I'm fine. But you seem off.

Paper Heron: You've been walking circles around me for a while.

Pip: You haven't moved for some time, just stood there with your eyes closed. Did something remind you of your past?

Paper Heron: I was thinking about the enchantment, and a memory surfaced. That's all.

Paper Heron: I didn't mean to worry you.

Pip: Are you certain you're alright? You seem a little sad.

Paper Heron: Do I? I ... I was just trying to think of a way to solve our problem here.

Paper Heron: I wanted to remember something from back then that could help us, but relying on my memory is, well, unreliable, at best.

Paper Heron: But you're right. Things here remind me of "forever" ago.

Paper Heron: I should think about what kind of person Finch ...

Paper Heron: No, I don't think that would help. I should focus on how she set the enchantment back then.

Paper Heron places her palm on the dry trunk and closes her eyes once more.

Paper Heron: ...

Some things in this world follow the great cycle of the Way, like the turning of the seasons, the gifts of nature, the rise and fall of a town.

Other things hold the vastness of the world within their minute form, like the color of apricot flowers, a spring breeze, and a simple spell cast by a hand gesture.

Like holding a familiar hand.

Paper Heron: I ...

Paper Heron: ...

Paper Heron: I've found her.

A slight gasp escapes Paper Heron's lip as she reaches within herself to hold that hand.

Paper Heron: She always wielded arcane techniques with more precision than others.

Her natural talent was nothing special; she had to rely on arcane techniques.

Paper Heron: She left space for future adjustments to the Qi. I can feel it, hidden in plain sight.

She was the most reliable one, so she was entrusted with managing the school's affairs.

Paper Heron: She was also skilled in sensing the flow of Qi.

A peer of the most observant, most caring kind.

Paper Heron: ...

Paper Heron: Finch.

Paper Heron: I want to remember more about you.

[English text unavailable]

COL-314109

Pip stares at a patch of dead grass by her feet, lost in thought.

The mule approaches and nibbles at the roots. She strokes its ear, her mind elsewhere.

Pip: You also think she seems sad, don't you?

Mule: Bray.

Pip: *sigh* It's all my fault.

Pip: When we go back, I'll apologize properly to the elder. It's the least I can do, right?

Pip: In the worst case, we figure another method out somewhere else.

Pip: ...

A petal falls on the withered grass.

Pip: Hmm?

As Pip looks up, her eyes widen in disbelief.

The sea of dead grass shifts from gray-yellow to tender green, and in the center, the dying apricot tree bursts into life.

Great clusters of apricot blossoms weigh down the branches, like a waterfall of flowers.

Petals, light and thin, drift on the gentle breeze like soft snow, vanishing the instant they land.

Pip cradles a petal in the palm of her hand. It feels alive, moist, and full.

Pip: The flowers?!

A strangeness unlike anything that has come before. Never have there been so many flowers at once.

It's as if all the apricot flowers of the last two hundred years have come into bloom at once.

Under the tree, Paper Heron rests her hand against the tree's gnarled trunk. Her white jade sword is drawn in her other hand, its white Qi wrapping around her.

Pip: What-What is this?

Paper Heron: Hmm. This tree has good fortune.

Paper Heron: Its Qi wasn't fully cut off, see. Once the flow cleared, all the life stored over the years burst forth.

Paper Heron gazes up at the tree full of flowers, her expression hidden.

Paper Heron: It's beautiful.

Pip: You found a way to fix it!

Paper Heron: No. Not exactly.

Paper Heron: I destroyed the old enchantment.

Pip: You did? Why didn't I think of something so simple?

Pip: No, I couldn't even see how the Qi flowed. Even if the idea had struck me, I wouldn't have known where to start. Heron, you're amazing!

Paper Heron: You shouldn't doubt yourself. Like I said, the enchantment wasn't complex.

Paper Heron: It's just this may have been the last thing she left in this world.

Pip: The last thing she left?

She blankly parrots the words, her voice absent of their original meaning.

Paper Heron: Yes. This was my senior sister's work.

Pip: And you just destroyed it?

Paper Heron: The enchantment needed mending, reweaving, every two hundred years. But there's no one left who knows how.

Paper Heron: Even if we'd kept it, it would have faded over time.

Paper Heron: You needn't worry. I used my school's sword to set the Qi flow right again.

Paper Heron: Even without anyone to tend it, there should be no more trouble.

Pip: You mean the Qi here will never stagnate again?

Paper Heron: Exactly.

Pip: ...

Pip: And is the old enchantment gone forever? No trace remains?

Petals drift down, landing on Pip's hair and shoulders and in Paper Heron's open hand.

Paper Heron: Yes. Nothing remains.

[English text unavailable]

COL-314110

Elder: Look! The flowers! They're really blooming!

Elder: This calls for a celebration! I'll head into town and buy some wine for us, the real good stuff! You just wait right here!

Pip: What? Wait! Please, there's no need to go to all that trouble.

Pip: He waited all this time for it to bloom, only to take off the moment it does. Can you believe it?

Paper Heron: So what? We have nothing but time ahead.

Pip: Really? But ...

Pip lowers her voice to just above a whisper.

Pip: But he's nearly 80 years old.

Paper Heron: Hmm? Did you say something?

Pip: Nothing, never mind. I think the sun will set soon.

Paper Heron: You're right. We should rest while it's still shining.

Paper Heron stretches out on the revivified grass, and Pip takes a seat beside her.

Pip: Where will you go after this?

Paper Heron: I'm not sure. I've left matters in Huanzhou with a friend, so perhaps it's time I explored somewhere new.

Paper Heron: And you?

Pip: Maybe I'll go home. I still have a lot to learn.

Pip: Actually, I slipped away without telling anyone.

Paper Heron: I suspected as much. You're too young to be out here alone. Your family must be worried about you.

Soft blades of grass press against Paper Heron's fingertips, a sign that they're still growing.

Pip: I have another question.

Paper Heron: Go ahead.

Pip: Have you lived a long time?

Pip: The things you mentioned on the way here, the East Port being busy once—they're all from the past.

Pip: And the story of the immortal in Huanzhou dates back nearly two hundred years.

Pip: ...

Pip: I'm sorry. It's alright if you don't want to talk about it. Just forget I asked.

The wind brushes against Paper Heron's hair.

Paper Heron: That's quite alright. Yes, it's true. Not much gets past you.

Paper Heron: But I didn't intend to. It's hard to explain. Just think of me like the old man's tree. I, too, have suffered a long illness.

Pip: What does it feel like to live for so long?

Paper Heron: Hmm. Well ...

Paper Heron: It doesn't feel so special. When you're ill for a long time, you almost forget what it's like to be well.

Pip: Why call it an illness? Many people dream of living long lives. Even in stories, that's what the Daoists sought.

Paper Heron: You shouldn't believe everything you read in stories!

Paper Heron: And from what books, pray tell, did you find this information?

Pip: *Legend of the Getian*, *The White Horse Immortal: A Tale of Medicine*, and *Three Years of Strange Dreams: A Collection*.

Paper Heron: So *Legend of the Getian* is still popular, even after two hundred years, eh? I remember a story about a mortal seeking the Way from the Getian clan. He descends the mountain, only to discover that a thousand years have passed.

Paper Heron: Those stories talk of immortals desiring the mortal world or mortals yearning for the immortal realm. At their core, they describe what one cannot attain.

Paper Heron: ...

Paper Heron: My senior sister once said that, as a person ages, time seems to speed up.

Paper Heron: I didn't argue then, but deep down, I disagreed.

Paper Heron: When you're young, the blooming and fading of flowers marks a season. That time doesn't change, even decades later. Flowers still bloom. Seasons still pass. Everything feels just as it did.

Paper Heron: But now, I see she was right.

Paper Heron: The first ten years feel slow. But the next ten are easier to endure.

Paper Heron: After that, the days just pass, one after another.

Pip gazes at the sky.

Pip: I ... I don't quite understand.

Pip: I'll be seventeen soon, so for me, this is the seventeenth spring.

Pip: Paper Heron, how many springs have you seen?

Paper Heron: ...

Paper Heron: I don't remember. You certainly ask tricky questions.

Mule: Bray—

Not far away, the mule lifts its head, braying and running off as if it spots something.

Pip: I'll go get it!

Paper Heron: No need to rush, eh? It won't get far.

Pip: But ...

Paper Heron: It likely knows this area better than us. It'll come back if it wishes it.

Pip: No, I made a promise. I have to keep it.

Paper Heron: What promise?

Pip: When we met today, I said I would help you anytime you needed it.

Pip: I wasn't sure how and when I would give it, but, at the very least, I can fetch your mule.

Paper Heron: My mule?

She looks up, surprised, propping herself on her elbow to better see Pip.

Pip: Yes! The mule should go to the one who fixed the Qi flow, no, to the one who saved the tree.

Pip: So it belongs to you now!

Paper Heron: Well, I suppose it'll give me a companion on my travels.

Pip: He's a slow thing, but it's not as though you're in a hurry.

The sound of the mule's steps grows quieter with each passing second.

Pip: I should go check on it. You stay here, alright? I'll be right back.

Paper Heron: Sure. You'd better be quick.

Paper Heron lays her head back down.

The rustling of the grass quiets, and the rays of sunlight feel warm on her skin. It's not long before she closes her eyes and drifts off to sleep.

Paper Heron: Seventeen ...

Paper Heron: The year I went down the mountain with Finch, I was seventeen then too, I think.

Paper Heron: ...

A soft rustle from the bush rouses her attention.

Mule: Bray.

Paper Heron: Hmm? You're back? Where's Pip?

She pats the mule's neck affectionately.

The mule ignores her instead, shaking its ears and walking over to the tree to munch on the new grass.

Paper Heron: Good timing. You can help me think ...

Paper Heron: How many springs have I seen?

...

How many springs have I seen?

The same spring breeze blows, the same vitalized grass sways, and the mule gives no answer.

Is it two hundred springs?

Twenty?

One?

...

Or has she lost all her springs?

Pearl Finch: Master, I thought long and hard on the matter yesterday. Please don't be too harsh with her.

Pearl Finch: We will all leave one day.

Pearl Finch: And when she does, she will walk a long, lonely road.

Pearl Finch: ...

Pearl Finch: Don't make her loneliness any heavier to bear.